

“Without promotion, something terrible happens...nothing!” – attributed to Phineas Taylor Barnum

“The Greatest Showman,” directed with verve and panache by [Michael Gracey](#), is an unabashed piece of pure entertainment, punctuated by 11 memorable songs composed by Oscar- and Tony-winning duo [Benj Pasek](#) and [Justin Paul](#), who composed the songs for “[La La Land](#),” as well as the current Broadway hit *Dear Evan Hansen*. The film is made for the whole family to enjoy, and so it leaves out many of the darker elements (explored in the 1980 Broadway musical *Barnum*, music by [Cy Coleman](#)). This is a difficult tightrope to walk, but credit is due to Gracey, a perfectly cast [Hugh Jackman](#), and the entire cast, who play this story in the spirit in which it was written (by [Jenny Bicks](#) and [Bill Condon](#)). “The Greatest Showman” positions itself as a story celebrating diversity, and the importance of embracing all kinds.

There are those who will see this as a rose-colored-glasses view of what was a pretty exploitive situation. But in a 19th and early 20th century context, the circus and then vaudeville were welcoming places where those who had skills or who were rejected by society could find a home. Barnum put “misfit toys” onstage, saying, in essence, “Aren’t they amazing?” (all while filling his pockets. For more thoughts on P.T. Barnum’s barely acknowledged influence on American culture author [Trav S.D.’s 2005 lecture at the Barnum Museum in Bridgeport, CT](#) is a good place to start.) [Cary Grant](#), who had a harsh poor childhood, got his start as a tumbler in a vaudeville troupe. Years later he described his revelatory first visit to the Bristol Hippodrome:

*“The Saturday matinee was in full swing when I arrived backstage; and there I suddenly found my inarticulate self in a dazzling land of smiling, jostling people wearing and not wearing all sorts of costumes and doing all sorts of clever things. And that’s when I knew! What other life could there be but that of an actor? They happily traveled and toured. They were classless, cheerful, and carefree. They gaily laughed, lived, and loved.”*

That’s what “The Greatest Showman” captures.